Late into the night, while waiting for her next text, I'd tap the American's name into Google. Hundreds of photos, each more dazzling. I wondered if she was googling me too. I hoped not.

Before turning out the light I asked how long she was going to be in London. Damn—she was leaving soon. She had to get back to Canada to resume filming her show.

I asked if I could see her before she left.

I watched the phone, waiting for the answer, staring at the endlessly fluttering ellipsis.

…

Then: *Sure!*

Great. Now: Where to meet?

I suggested my place.

Your place? On a first date! I don't think so.

No, I didn't mean it like that.

She didn't realize that being royal meant being radioactive, that I was unable to just meet at a coffee shop or pub. Reluctant to give her a full explanation, I tried to explain obliquely about the risk of being seen. I didn't do a good job.

She suggested an alternative. Soho House at 76 Dean Street. It was her headquarters whenever she came to London. She'd reserve us a table in a quiet room.

No one else would be around.

The table would be under her name.

Meghan Markle.

2.

AFTER TEXTING half the night, into the wee hours, I groaned when that alarm rang at dawn. Time to get on Sir Keith's boat. But I also felt grateful. A sailing race was the only way I'd be able to put down my phone.

And I needed to put it down, just for a spell, to collect my wits.

To pace myself.